Indeed, IOs are not just collections of member states but dynamic entities driven by mission-focused bureaucrats and leaders who are deeply committed to their survival and the preservation of the international order. This conceptualization draws on political sociology, which highlights how IO staff are socialized into their organization's unique culture and practices, transforming them into stewards of the IO's mission rather than mere representatives of their home countries (Chwieroth 2015; Honig 2018). Career concerns loom large—when populist states retreat or disengage, IOs often face resource constraints that lead to program cuts, staff layoffs, and, in extreme cases, organizational collapse (von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2024b). Populist obstruction also undermines field operations, as staff rely on state cooperation to achieve performance targets. For instance, World Bank staff are evaluated using quantitative benchmarks, which can become unattainable when member states refuse to share critical data or hinder program implementation.

But beyond career pressures, IO bureaucrats and leaders are ideologically driven. Many staff join IOs out of a genuine commitment to international cooperation and causes, often sacrificing higher-paying private sector opportunities (Honig 2018). Once inside, they are steeped in the organization's norms and practices, developing a deep loyalty to its mission (Weaver 2008; Clark and Dolan 2021). IO leaders, meanwhile, often pursue agendas shaped by their ideological beliefs (Copelovitch and Rickard 2021). These personal and professional motivations make IO personnel determined to resist populist efforts to undermine their institutions.

For nonpopulist member states—and especially for powerful state backers of global governance—IOs are critical tools for advancing their interests. These states often use IOs to promote economic and political liberalization in target countries, attaching policy conditions to aid or loans and socializing governments into adopting liberal norms (Li, Sy, and McMurray 2015; Kentikelenis, Stubbs, and King 2016). Such states benefit from the stability and predictability of the existing international order and have a clear incentive to maintain IOs as vehicles for their influence (Johnston 2008; Ikenberry 2011a). The United States and many Western European states, who were the primary architects of the liberal order, have historically benefited from international cooperation in these ways. Such states may thus view populist attacks on IOs as direct threats to their